alignment meant India did not need to consider someone a friend or enemy because of the friendship or hostility of a superpower. It also enabled India to safeguard its territorial unity by staying out of disputes it might be drawn into through alliances. Above all, non-alignment provided a platform from which India could attempt to lead other developing countries at a time when India lacked resources to be a superpower itself. Nehru argued that other countries would respect India only if it was not ‘a camp follower’.

The expansion of India’s economic and military capabilities, coupled with the end of the cold war and the blocs it spawned, have diminished the need for India to emphasize non-alignment and to seek leadership through rhetorical moralizing. The pursuit of strategic autonomy, however, persists and has become the reason for a diverse foreign policy that enables India to deal with the world’s major issues without being tied down to a single great power or set of powers.

In a recent article, Itty Abraham, disagrees with the view that non-alignment was the rational outcome of a calculated policy. According to Abraham, the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) did not emerge ‘fully blown from the collective minds of Nehru, Nasser and Tito in Brioni in 1956’.[5] Abraham asserts that NAM was rather the ‘outcome of a sophisticated analysis of world order as well as the difficult political choices facing a leadership that was very much on the defensive in contemporary regional affairs during the late 1950s and early 1960s’. [6] Worried about global conflict arising from the two blocs, non-alignment was seen as the buffer that would reduce friction and allow peaceful outcomes.

Often critiqued for adopting a moralistic or preachy foreign policy, this policy actually served key goals: India sought leadership of Asia and believed it was a future great power but it lacked the resources to achieve this goal through military or economic means. As Werner Levi states: ‘For a nation with few effective means and little spare energy to influence international events, the idea of making a virtue of staying out of